

Question ID: 6cf906fc

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	Easy

Question

The following text is adapted from José Martí’s 1891 poem “At the Salon” (translated by Cecil Charles in 1898). The speaker describes a painting featuring a female figure.

From the sterile soil no ray
Of hope in a blade of green,
Nor sheltering roof is seen—
Though the skies are heavy and gray.

Ah, this is the woman fair
Who stole away my heart
In the splendid halls of art
Yester-e’en as I wandered there!

As used in the text, what does the word “sheltering” most nearly mean?

Answer

- A. Protective
- B. Restrictive
- C. Affectionate
- D. Suspicious

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because as used in the text, "sheltering" most nearly means protective. In the text, the speaker describes a painting featuring a female figure. The speaker ultimately confesses to falling in love with the woman in the painting, who has "stole[n] away" the speaker’s heart, but first the speaker describes elements of the painting’s setting. These include sterile soil, barren fields with "no ray / Of hope in a blade of green"—a description that conveys a mood of melancholy and forlornness, possibly reflecting the speaker’s own sadness at falling in love with an image that can’t return the speaker’s love. The text continues by stating that there’s no "sheltering roof" in the painting, even though the "skies are heavy and gray," showing signs of an impending storm. Generally, a roof’s intended purpose is to provide protection from the elements, and in this context, a roof would offer shelter and protection from the gathering storm.

Choice B is incorrect because nothing in the text suggests that a roof would be restrictive—that is, that it would limit or restrain something in some way. Although a roof would provide some cover from stormy winds and rain, it wouldn’t limit the wind and rain, only deflect them. Choice C is incorrect because there’s nothing in the text to suggest that if a "sheltering roof" were present in the painting, it would be affectionate, or loving